

# So you're thinking about construction management

The short version — written for you, not about you.

Everything that matters, none of the bits written for your parents.

Or maybe you aren't — because almost nobody mentions this one.

We scored twenty-seven careers on how exposed they are to AI. A site superintendent came out at **3.3 out of 10**.

That's better than **licensed engineering (4.0)**. Better than **architecture (5.0)**. Better than a business degree (7.6).

Median pay is around \$106,980, projected growth is 9% — "much faster than average" per the government's own classification — and there are roughly 46,800 openings a year.

And your school careers office probably hasn't said a word about it.

---

## The 60-second version

- Site-based construction management scores better than engineering, architecture or business.
  - **No graduate degree. No licence exam in most places.** Progression runs on competence.
  - The thing protecting it is unusual: **there are multiple ways in**, and they compete with each other.
  - The office roles score 7.4. The site roles score 3.3. That's a 4.1-point gap on the same project.
  - And the AI data centre buildout is driving demand — \$100 billion of it in 2026 alone.
- 

## Why it's protected

**You have to physically be there.** Walking the site, checking the work, seeing what's actually happening rather than what's in the report. Construction sites are among the *hardest* environments for automation — nothing is where the drawing says it is.

**Every site is genuinely new.** Different ground, different team, different problems, arriving without warning.

**And you're accountable when someone gets hurt.** Safety responsibility attaches to a named person, and that's not a technical problem to solve.

---

# The thing that actually makes this career resilient

Here's the argument, and it applies well beyond construction.

Most careers have **one** way in. A law degree. A medical degree. A CS degree into a graduate scheme. When that route narrows — which is what's happening across this whole index — the whole profession narrows with it.

**Construction management has at least four.**

- A construction management degree
- Coming up through a trade and moving into supervision — completely normal here, not a second-class route
- Engineering graduates crossing over
- Estimators and office staff moving to site

**And they compete with each other.** No single gatekeeper controls entry.

Plus the entry work itself is physical — an assistant superintendent learns by walking the site and chasing subcontractors, which can't be automated the way a junior analyst's spreadsheets can.

So when you're weighing any career, ask: how many doors are there? One door is fragile. Four is resilient even when one of them narrows.

## The scores

| ROLE                                    | SCORE |
|-----------------------------------------|-------|
| Site superintendent                     | 3.3   |
| Construction project manager            | 4.2   |
| Estimator / quantity surveyor           | 6.3   |
| Scheduler / planner                     | 7.0   |
| Preconstruction / document coordination | 7.4   |

A 4.1-point gap on the same project. The person in the mud and the person managing the document set work on the same building, and one of them is doing work a machine handles

well.

**Which matters practically**, because the office jobs are the ones that look like promotions. Worth knowing that before someone offers you one.

---

## Where the demand actually is

The industry is genuinely short of people:

- **92% of contractors** report difficulty filling open positions (AGC survey)
- **80%** specifically struggle with salaried roles
- **45%** say shortages are directly causing project delays
- Around **349,000 net new workers** needed in 2026, and 456,000 in 2027

**And the AI buildout is a direct driver.** Reporting suggests tech companies could put upwards of \$100 billion into US data centre construction in 2026 alone, on top of CHIPS Act megaprojects, healthcare and defence work.

Same pattern as electricians: a career protected from AI that's simultaneously being pulled by it.

---

## One honest thing about that

We'd rather tell you than let the shortage numbers oversell it.

The construction hiring rate hit 3.3% in February 2026 — the lowest on record since the government started measuring it in 2000.

That sits oddly next to "92% of contractors can't fill positions." Both are true.

What's happening: construction spending growth has slowed, so firms are starting fewer projects and hiring cautiously — while still being unable to find experienced people for the work they do have.

**It's a shortage of qualified people in a market that's hiring carefully.** Not the same as a boom.

The skills shortage is demographic and will outlast the cycle. But if you graduate during a slow period, it'll feel tighter than the headlines suggest.

---

## What we won't soften

**Construction is cyclical.** It rises and falls with credit conditions and public spending in a way nursing and teaching don't.

**The hours are long and the weather doesn't care.** A superintendent absorbs pressure from the client, the designer, the subcontractors, the inspectors and their own firm — often simultaneously.

**Responsibility arrives early and it's real.** Safety accountability isn't abstract.

**And the median isn't the headline.** Most construction managers aren't on \$170,000. The middle of the market is closer to \$105,000 — the average gets pulled up by big metros and complex infrastructure work.

---

## Where the money actually is

Worth knowing early, because these are choices rather than luck:

- **BIM and platform fluency: +10–15% pay.** That's the single best skill investment here.
  - **Sector matters a lot:** heavy civil \$121,060, commercial \$120,010, specialty trade \$102,140, residential \$91,150
  - **Data centres, healthcare and industrial** carry premiums for complexity
  - Certifications (CCM, PMP, OSHA) typically add \$5,000–\$15,000
- 

## Does this actually sound like you?

It suits people who:

- Are **practical and organised** in equal measure — that specific combination is the job
- Are comfortable being **responsible for other people's safety**
- Can **get people who disagree to agree** — most of the job, honestly
- Would rather be **moving than at a desk**
- **Want the thing to exist afterwards**

Harder if you need predictable indoor hours, find conflict draining, want creative freedom (architecture is closer to that), or need stability through an economic cycle.

---

## What actually matters when picking a course

- **How much of the placement is actually on site, not in an office?**
- **Named contractor relationships** and real conversion rates
- **BIM taught properly**, as understanding rather than software training
- **What job titles do graduates have at six months** — site or office? That's a 4.1-point difference.

---

## Two things worth doing

**Get on a site.** Labouring, work experience, a summer with a contractor. **Nothing else builds the ability to read a site** — and that's the thing separating a good superintendent from a competent administrator.

**Then talk to both a site superintendent and a preconstruction manager** and ask each what their day looks like. The contrast between those two answers is basically this whole document.

---

## One last thing

If you like building things and someone has told you the options are "a trade" or "architecture" — **this is the third one.**

It pays more than both at the median. It scores better than both. You don't need a graduate degree or a licence exam. And you can get there from a trade, from a degree, or sideways from engineering.

It's the most overlooked good option we found, and the reason is mostly that it doesn't sound impressive at a dinner party.

---

## If you want to go further — three things worth twenty minutes

- **Construction Managers — Occupational Outlook Handbook** — the government's own data on pay, growth and openings, including the sector-by-sector breakdown.

- AGC construction data — the industry's own workforce survey. Where the 92% figure comes from.
  - Construction management career opportunities — on where demand is concentrated, including the data centre story.
- 

*There's a longer version behind this — full scores by role, how they were worked out, the honest downsides, what to ask a program, and where we might be wrong. Your parents have it.*